

## EPISODE 15 (SESSION 1)

# Into the Pit

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PRIMARY TEXT: GENESIS 37–40

When we use our new lens to look for “problems” in the Text, some stories begin to make more sense, and others begin to sit even more uncomfortably than they had before. And, maybe, that is the point. We see God choose a human, the best mankind had to offer in Abraham, and we watch God commit and draw near to this family at the highest and lowest points of their humanity.

**We watch God  
commit and  
draw near to  
this family...**

Whether it be their *chutzpah*, radical hospitality, or willingness to let go and trust the Story, each generation of this lineage holds to many of the same attributes and characteristics as the one before them. Sometimes even the near-exact same mistakes, repeating history instead of learning from it.

When we look at the remainder of Jacob’s life, especially how it plays out in his son’s actions, we find many problems, one being—what has happened to the radical hospitality of Abraham? What keeps one from withholding their hospitality and, instead, alienating others?

In these chapters in Genesis we see the resentment of the favorite son, Joseph, lead to his abandonment into a pit, near murder, and enslavement. Then we see the failure to care for and bring into the community the widowed daughter-in-law of Judah, Tamar. (And doesn’t her name meaning *upright* just add such weight to the surrounding stories of self-serving actions and lack of hospitality and restoration! If there’s a chiasm nearby, I’d love it to point right back here.)

**If there’s a  
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point right here!**

Now, what is behind these brash and selfish desires? Perhaps another look backward would be beneficial.

Maybe it all goes back to the near beginning—with two brothers. One brother (Cain) fears not being the “favorite,” or not being recognized or acknowledged for his efforts and sacrifices—not getting what he thinks is rightfully his or rightfully deserves from God. He forgets that God put in him the same attributes of Himself that he put in his brother Abel. Cain’s fear of not being enough—of not measuring up to the “ideal” brother beside him. Cain lets the beast crouching at the door win the battle, and makes a terrible choice rooted in his own selfishness, insecurity, and fear. He lost the path, and the promise, of the Story.

This fear of not getting what one has earned, whether it be due to birth order, which mother they were born of, or an aging, imperfect father declaring one the “favorite” ties itself in much of Israel’s history. The beast, as we may name it again here, continues to crouch at this family’s door, seeking to entangle itself in their insecurities, hoping they will forget they have been called, not just *good enough*, but *very good* from the get-go.

It’s tragic that even the smallest, fearful reaction—whether it was Abraham’s, Isaac’s, Jacob’s, or their sons’—let a foothold of doubt into the hearts of this beautiful family, resulting in generations of rifts within them.

This worry of not being enough or good enough that we wrestle with to this day seems to take root in selfishness and favoritism. A naming of a favorite wife, a favorite son, creating chaos and division—rifts in the family and ultimately in the Story. *If I am not the favorite, then who am I? Does Dad (or even God) not believe in my goodness?* Our insecurities then follow us from generation to generation. So we lie, we cheat, we destroy, and we learn the hard way that this chaos damages everyone—not just ourselves.

This family was called to be a blessing to all nations. Will they find the plot of the Story again? Remember their goodness, God’s promise to them, and their promises to God? Is there still hope for justice and restoration and redemption? How far will God go to remind them of His promise and blessing?

**...we learn the  
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## PRAYER

*God,  
There are many times when worry takes root,  
and I rely on my own means and dreams.  
Forgive me.  
There are many times when my selfishness wins,  
and I seek my personal gain over justice and goodness.  
Forgive me.  
In those times I’m deep in a pit of my own making,  
rescue me, God. And teach me, again,  
how to let go and trust in You.  
How to learn from my history, Your history,  
to bless and change the world from here on out.  
Amen*

# THE FOUR PILLARS

## EPISODE 15

BEMA Discipleship is built on four pillars; a **Four-Pillared Perspective** to help us remember **to elevate the words of God** (not ours) and help us identify the principles that we see recurring in the Story of God's people.

Here are some applications for this episode echoing the ideas of the four pillars:



### TEXT

*How could you meditate over these parts of the Story? What Text could you continue to meditate on, memorize, or dig deeper into? What could you review to add depth to your study?*



### COMMUNITY

*In what ways does your community encourage you and even challenge you? How does your community seek to bless and show hospitality to all?*



### DISCIPLESHIP

*Who in your life would benefit from a mentor-like relationship that helps them wrestle with difficult portions of the Text and its characters? What might the young people around you need to hear or see modeled?*



### WRESTLING

*What questions do you have after this lesson? About the loss of hospitality? About the women in the Story? Tamar or Jacob's less spoken of wives? Why this family, still? Wrestling is good—even if we feel like we have more questions than answers.*



### Are you a music listener?

Listen along to our BEMA Music Playlists on Spotify.

Song suggestions? Send them to [bemabesorah@gmail.com](mailto:bemabesorah@gmail.com).



BEMA SESSION 1



MEDITATION & PRAYER

# REFLECTION, APPLICATION & IMPACT

There are three emphases we are always thinking about in terms of application at BEMA. These may be stated explicitly at times, but often we will want you to do the work of finding ways to connect the dots to the things we are learning. Much of this is what makes the work of BEMA distinct as a ministry of Impact Campus Ministries.

## CREATING A SPACE SPIRITUAL FORMATION

*When was the last time you just sat or went for a walk with God? We believe that **if we do our part of creating space for God, He will fill it.** We want BEMA to foster practices that enable the Holy Spirit to do a work in and through us all, but creating and maintaining that space is difficult in our busy lives. How have you created a space to hear God speak to you or to just sit and be with you? How can you better maintain this space? What spiritual disciplines or discipleship assist in creating this space?*

## CONSIDERING CAMPUS YOUNG PEOPLE FOCUS

***We believe young adults are shaping the future of this world,** and they need the mentorship or guidance of people like you. They may carry hurts or traumas similar to the sons of Jacob. How can we help them seek justice and restoration before bitterness and vengeance takes over? In what ways could you come alongside young adults to show them what it means to trust the Story and believe in God's goodness for them and over them?*

## SACRED STATION THEOLOGY OF WORK

*This isn't just for our time at church or Bible study; this is about what we do at work every day. How we do our job and be a blessing to those we meet while doing it. Does our physical work (our 9–5 job) bring shalom or chaos? Do you carry a weight of worry of being or doing enough, or resentment in jealousy as if life is a competition? The way we manage our employees, interact with customers or coworkers, care for our children, or create products can bless others and the peace in our own hearts and minds. **The work we do every day, and how we approach it, is sacred and matters!***